

Lesson 12

Letting In The Good

In the last lesson, we talked about self-compassion, how you treat yourself through this very challenging process, stopping the internal attack and softening toward yourself instead of beating yourself up when things are challenging. That matters a lot because when you're constantly at war with yourself, there isn't any room for anything else.

But once you start treating yourself with some kindness, something else becomes possible, and this is where it gets good. You can start letting good back in. I wanna talk about something that was a huge part of my recovery because it's not just about stopping the harmful behaviors. It's not just about allowing sensations and accepting your situation.

There's another piece. You have to actively bring in things that feel good. For most of us who are sensitized, we have completely lost connection to joy, to relaxation, to relief, to things that are fulfilling. It is just gone. That makes sense because we've been in danger mode for so long that those circuits have gone dark.

They've just been offline. All of the brain's resources have been going toward protection and survival and vigilance. There's been nothing left for pleasure or ease or enjoyment. So it's not that you're choosing suffering over joy, it's that joy isn't even accessible to you anymore. You have forgotten what it feels like.

You've forgotten that it was even an option. Part of this work that we're doing here is remembering that I knew deep down that I could not just white knuckle my way through this. I couldn't just drudge through life and my obligations and hope that one day I'd feel better. I knew that at some point. My nervous system was going to need a different signal.

I had been sending it dangerous signals for so long through my behaviors, through my reactions, through my constant vigilance, and I understood that I needed to stop doing that. That's what we've been talking about all throughout this course, but stopping wasn't enough. I also needed to start sending safety signals, and one of the strongest safety signals you can send is.

I am doing something that feels good. I realized I was kind of gonna feel crappy either way. Like I could feel crappy and doom, scroll for nine hours, or I could feel crappy and have a dish of cinnamon rolls that I just baked. I could feel crappy at home, stuck in my house, afraid to go anywhere, or I could feel crappy on the beach in California.

I could feel crappy in bed hiding from my life, or I could feel crappy on a hike getting fresh air and vitamin D. Same level of crappy, but completely different input to my nervous system. And that really took so much pressure off. I was not trying to feel better. I wasn't using joy as a tool to make symptoms go away, but I was just choosing a better version of feeling bad.

And then something amazing started to happen, which I kind of always had a hunch would happen. I would be in the middle of doing something, baking or on a walk or watching something funny, and I would realize I hadn't thought about my symptoms in 20 minutes, sometimes longer. I just noticed I was in the moment engaged, and this caught me off guard at first because I had forgotten or believed that that wasn't even possible.

Those old circuits, the one for pleasure, for enjoyment, for ease, for joy, they started coming back online. I started using them again and surprise, surprise, they got stronger. The circuits you use get stronger. The ones you don't use get weaker. For so long, all of my attention and my energy had been feeding the fear.

Pain circuits, they were incredibly strong, remarkably strong. The joy circuits had basically shut down from neglect. So part of recovery is deliberately feeding the other circuits, giving them something to work with, even when it doesn't feel like much. Even when you can barely access the good feeling underneath, you keep doing it.

And over time it starts to shift. I am not talking about being toxically positive. I'm not asking you to pretend everything is fine or force yourself to feel happy or feel joy. That's not possible immediately when you're sensitized and trying to force it is just gonna create more pressure, which we obviously don't want to do.

And I'm not talking about distraction either. Distraction. Is trying to not feel what you're feeling. It's avoidance. This is different. You still feel what you're feeling. You just do something nourishing. At the same time, you are choosing to include something good in your day. Even though you feel terrible, you're giving your brain a different experience than the one it has been stuck in.

And you might be thinking that, I don't even know what brings me joy anymore. I've lost touch with that completely. That is very normal. That is part of sensitization, and you're going to have to explore. Try things. See what lands even just a little bit. It doesn't have to be big. It can be small. A cup of coffee that you actually sit down, drink slowly and enjoy a show that makes you laugh.

Music you used to love. Five minutes outside a conversation with someone you care about. Baking something, creating something, moving your body in a way that feels okay. The bar here is low. We are not looking for ecstatic joy. We are looking for anything that sends a slightly different signal than the one that your system has been receiving, and it might not feel good at first.

Please. Prepare yourself for that. You might do something that's supposed to be enjoyable and feel absolutely nothing, or you might feel the crappy feelings right alongside it, or it may just feel bad. That's okay. That's expected. You keep doing it anyway. We're not doing it to feel good immediately.

For me, in my recovery, this looked like baking.

I just committed to being the best cinnamon roll baker you could be. I was doing it five times a week. I would make them and I would deliver them to my family, and they loved them. And it was connection for me. It kept my hands busy. It gave me something to focus on, to use my attention on. It connected me to people that I loved.

And even when I felt terrible while I was learning and doing it, like I have a vivid memory of how challenging it was because it was such a mixed signal. I was supposed to be on a chair in my kitchen suffering. This was different. It was better than sitting on that chair in my kitchen, doom scrolling. It also looked like getting outside, going on walks, beginning to take trips to places with big open skies.

There was something about the openness that helped me, I guess probably because it was the opposite of that tunnel vision I had when I was frantically trying to find a solution. It looked like these small moments of pleasure that I gave myself permission to have, even though nothing was resolved, even though I still felt.

Pretty awful. And that permission matters because a lot of people won't let themselves experience anything good while they are suffering. Like, I get it. It feels wrong somehow. Like you should be focused on fixing the problem, not enjoying your life. The problem is that belief is part of what keeps you stuck.

If you are waiting for the suffering to end before you let any good in, you're cutting yourself off from one of the things that actually helps in a major way. You have to let yourself have good things. You have to let yourself rest and laugh and enjoy something. Your symptoms being there doesn't disqualify you from that.

And I wanna say something that I think is very easy to miss. This isn't just something you do on the hard days. This isn't a tool you only pull out when things are really bad. Your life needs to include joy. Period, not as a medicine and not as a tool or a coping strategy. It needs to be included as part of being a person who's just living.

So many of us have built lives where joy is completely absent. Everything is an obligation and we're just trying to manage our lives and get through the day. That's not sustainable for anyone, sensitized or not, and for those of us who are sensitized, that absence of good is kind of part of what got us here.

So you're not just healing and recovering, you are rebuilding a life that actually has good things in it. That's part of the work. At some point, my nervous system started to get the memo. It was so exciting. It started to learn that life was not just danger and pain and vigilance like I had believed for the previous 20 years.

There was also. Connection, ease and enjoyment. And the more I included that, the more those circuits strengthened, the more accessible those states became to me. I wasn't just managing my

symptoms anymore. I was actually starting to feel better. I was starting to heal. This is part of how you desensitize.

You stop reinforcing the old patterns, very important, but then you start building something new at the same time. So as you move through this process, I want you to ask yourself, what am I bringing in? What am I feeding? Am I only focused on what I need to stop doing, or am I giving my system something good to work with?

You're going to feel crappy sometimes. That's part of this. You might as well include something that reminds your nervous system that life isn't only suffering, and you might be surprised. Those moments where you forget about your symptoms, where you actually feel okay. For a moment at first, and then a day, and then a week, and then a month.

They're going to start happening more often. In the next lesson, I wanna talk about why healing doesn't happen through tools. It happens through living. I.